

# PICTURE THIS. A PESKY HOUSEFLY BUZZES IN AND OUT OF YOUR EARS. YOU SWAT IT AND BRUSH IT ASIDE. BUT WHAT IF THIS FLY IS A VENGEFUL REINCARNATE, OUT TO AVENGE ITS MURDER IN A PREVIOUS BIRTH?

**ABSURD IN REALITY**, surely, but what of a movie? Even there, most people would laugh the idea off, but not S.S. Rajamouli. The director made a VFX-heavy, bilingual revenge saga out of it—*Eega* in Telugu and *Naan Ee* in Tamil—and won the hearts of millions of filmgoers, with a small twist. *Eega* (meaning fly) was a box office super hit in the South, but the Hindi-dubbed *Makkhi* was a flop in the North.

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It's a little like his own story. As a fly trying to get his film to more audiences, he was called a visionary for taking a Telugu film to Tamil Nadu (in Tamil), Karnataka (Kannada), and Kerala (Malayalam) for the first time. "At the same time, I was ridiculed because I went to the North with *Eega* and it didn't succeed there," says the 48-year-old director, appearing over a Zoom video call. A shock of salt-and-pepper hair complements a black T-shirt proudly proclaiming 'RRR', his most recent work, which set the cash registers ablaze. The fictitious tale about two real-life Indian revolutionaries in the pre-Independence era grossed ₹1,111 crore worldwide, including ₹265 crore in Hindi net collections alone.

But before that, he stunned the country and beyond with his two-part magnum opus *Baahubali: The Beginning* and *Baahubali: The Conclusion*, and effectively altered Indian cinema's timelines forever—as pre- and post-*Baahubali*. As audiences lapped up *Katappa ne Baahubalikokyunmaara?* [Why did Katappa kill Baahubali?], a market was not just created in the North for theatrical releases of Hindi-dubbed south Indian films, but it also paved the way for them to hammer Hindi films in their home turf. Released in 2015, *Baahubali: The Beginning* set the pace with an impressive lifetime gross of ₹500 crore in India to become the country's highest-grossing movie at the time. The next *Baahubali* edition rolled in ₹1,416.9 crore. And more recently, four successive super

hits from the South—*Pushpa: The Rise Part-1*, *RRR*, *KGF: Chapter 2* and *Vikram* (to a much smaller extent in Hindi as *Vikram: Hitlist*)—have grossed more than ₹3,000 crore worldwide, including nearly ₹800 crore in Hindi net collections. Comparatively, the best-performing Hindi films lately—*Gangubai Kathiawadi*, *The Kashmir Files* and *Bhool Bhulaiyaa 2*—have together grossed ₹811 crore worldwide, including ₹566 crore net collections in India.

From January 2020 to April 2022, of the country's ₹9,759-crore cumulative gross box office collection, the four south Indian languages contributed 57.3 per cent. Hindi managed 31 per cent. Seven of the top 10 grossers in this span were from the South, pegs Ormax Media data.

Clearly, Rajamouli has sown the seeds of south Indian cinema's dominance of Indian movie theatres across the country, with others following in his footsteps. The tale of this transformation, with many nuances and twists, would make for a movie of its own.



**LET'S STAY WITH *Makkhi*** for a bit. The movie, which released in 2012, earned cult status on TV (the Hindi-dubbed version) and taught Rajamouli a valuable lesson—he needed the right people to present a film in Hindi. Not too far away, it brought similar realisations to producers Shobu Yarlagadda and Prasad Devineni, who would go on to produce the *Baahubali* films. "*Makkhi* should have been the first pan-India film. That didn't happen and it was a learning for us as to why it didn't hap-